kar, Syama Prasad Mookerjee, Deen Dayal Upadhyay and Atal Bihari Vajpayee, among others.

The party has identified tribals and SCs as groups that can help push up the vote share to 51 per cent. While there has been a clear plan to woo tribals—the President, the prime minister and the Union home minister visited the state for a tribal festival, towns and amenities were renamed after tribal icons, and tribal-specific schemes were announced—the party began focusing on SCs after the recent bypolls in which it lost the SC-reserved Raigaon seat to the Congress. "We held that seat earlier, but the SC voters moved away from us. A clear message has been sent to workers to work among the community," says a party functionary involved in the plan. The party's state unit has decided to develop SC leaders at the local level to reach out to the community.

While party leaders are confident of pulling off the aspired jump in vote share, challenges remain. During monitoring, Bhopal-based functionaries are still finding booths where the data being uploaded on Sangathan is not accurate. The plan's success also depends on parties other than the BJP and the Congress being unable to bag a significant number of votes. Buoyed by its Punjab victory, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) will likely make inroads in Madhya Pradesh too, and it's not clear whether it will be the BJP's or the Congress's votes that AAP or some other party would cut into. Meanwhile, the Congress too has unveiled a plan to strengthen the party at the booth and mandal levels. What seems inevitable is that the big fight will be over who dominates the electoral scene at the level of its basic building bloc—the polling booth. ■

INTERVIEW » SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN

"Like sugar in milk, those who joined from other parties became one with me"

On March 23, **SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN** *completed two years in office during his fourth term as chief minister of Madhya Pradesh. A few weeks ago, he had become the longest serving BJP CM, overtaking former Chhattisgarh CM Raman Singh. Chouhan spoke to* **RAHUL NORONHA** *on the challenges in his fourth term, his preparations for the 2023 assembly poll and his newfound 'Bulldozer Mama' image. Excerpts from the interview:*

Q. How has your fourth term as CM been different from previous ones, especially since a third of your cabinet this time consists of former Congress leaders?

A. The circumstances during the fourth term were very different due to Covid. A lockdown was imposed a day after I was sworn in. The coffers were empty, but we were able to overcome it with everyone's help. I am happy that I have been able to work with (Jyotiraditya) Scindiaji and the group that came with him in the same way as I worked with my cabinet in the first, second or third terms. Not for a day have I felt that they have come from another party. Much like sugar dissolves in milk, they have become one with me in work.

Q. You have advocated a shift from agriculture to industry. Creation of jobs is a big issue in the country. What is being done on that front?

A. We are now focusing on value addition in agriculture and have identified one product per district. The idea is to enhance income in agriculture, but we are also aware that agriculture has limitations and we will have to shift to industry rapidly. Investment is coming in sectors such as textiles, semiconductors and auto parts, besides certain MSMEs. We are developing two expressways around which industrial clusters would be built and also planning an investor summit in early November. We have an 'employment day' every month, when we announce new employment made available. The focus now is to also create self-employment through schemes so that people become job providers rather than job seekers.

Q. Your previous terms were marked by social sector schemes such as Laadli Laxmi, which helped you win elections. But you haven't announced any such scheme this term...

A. Many of the schemes we started such as the Teerth Darshan Yojana have been adopted by other state governments. There are 43 lakh beneficiaries of Laadli Laxmi and the first lot is now in Class XII. One has to think of various ways in which their future needs can be taken care of, which is why we are going to announce Laadli Laxmi 2.0. There are new initiatives too, including 18 for tribal communities. Provisions of the PESA (Panchayat Extension to

"It's not that I started using bulldozers only now. **I've always said I'll be soft on good people, but tough on those who are evil**"